Quotes in New Scientist

17 October 2026 issue · all 128 quotes of what people said or wrote, copied exactly as printed, in page order. "…" marks words of the surrounding sentence that were left out; a quote broken by "says X" keeps both parts. Part 2 lists the 23 highlighted pull quotes. Words in quotation marks that are only names or terms (e.g. "warm pool", "PhotoTat", "Viking") are not quotes and are not listed. The Roman telescope interview (pages 40–43) is printed as questions and answers without quotation marks, so only its pull quotes appear here.

El Niño special report (pages 4–11)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Who said it	Page
1	"Based on that alone, one might not have expected this event to become as strong as it has,"	**Michael McPhaden** US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration	4
2	"The thermocline is currently more than 80 metres deeper than normal in some areas,"	**Michael McPhaden** US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration	5
3	"It's honestly an open question from my stance."	**Michael Mann** University of Pennsylvania	5
4	"The models [are] nearly equally split as to whether the amplitude of El Niño events is likely to increase or decrease with anthropogenic warming."	**Michael Mann** University of Pennsylvania	5
5	"It gives us a glimpse of what is coming down the pike if we continue to warm the planet with carbon pollution. Warmer oceans, more evaporation, bigger flooding events, hotter continents and worse droughts leading to more extensive and destructive wildfires."	**Michael Mann** University of Pennsylvania	5
6	"I expect that this super El Niño event will drive multiple climate-regime shifts like we've seen after past super El Niño events,"	**Jeff Masters** hurricane specialist	5
7	"Regime shifts tend to cause considerable trouble – significant disruptions to ecosystems and to the humans that depend on them."	**Jeff Masters** hurricane specialist	5
8	"We are experiencing a very strong El Niño event,"	**Jong-Seong Kug** Seoul National University	6
9	"Based on our study, such an extreme event could substantially increase the likelihood that various components of the Earth system are pushed toward, or even across, regime-shift thresholds."	**Jong-Seong Kug** Seoul National University	6
10	"Our civilisation is adapted to the climate of the 20th century, and it is costly and disruptive to be forced to deal with sudden climate regime-shifts,"	**Jeff Masters** hurricane specialist	6
11	…this was a disaster of "truly planetary magnitude".	**Mike Davis** historian, in the book Late Victorian Holocausts	6
12	That was the "big bang" for El Niño research…	**Michael McPhaden** US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration	6
13	"Being forewarned is being forearmed. If you know something is coming and it can have really damaging impacts, you have some choices to make,"	**Michael McPhaden** US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration	7
14	"The longer you have to prepare, the more options you have. And the better off you may be in the end,"	**Michael McPhaden** US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration	7
15	This El Niño "is happening at a very bad time"…	**Richard Seager** Columbia University, New York	7

El Niño special report (pages 4–11)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Who said it	Page
16	“We have much better public health systems,”	**Michael McPhaden** US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration	7
17	“We have much better understanding of disease and disease controls. And we have humanitarian organisations, and we have social safety nets, that will not let 50 million people die like happened in 1877-78.”	**Michael McPhaden** US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration	7
18	“If the crops are stressed, they’re more likely to get attacked,”	**Tom Chadwick** Laines Organic Farm, UK	8
19	“It is worrying, the unpredictability of it,”	**Rosa Farber** Laines Organic Farm, UK	8
20	“It’s just an unknown.”	**Rosa Farber** Laines Organic Farm, UK	8
21	“The UK may be willing to pay top dollar,”	**Christian Jaccarini** Energy and Climate Intelligence Unit	8
22	“It doesn’t mean people won’t go hungry somewhere else.”	**Christian Jaccarini** Energy and Climate Intelligence Unit	8
23	“Inflation is a big challenge over the next few months,”	**Akshay Deoras** University of Reading	8
24	“With El Niño, you have these phenomena of changes in weather patterns across the whole globe, which is part of why it makes it so difficult,”	**Monika Zurek** University of Oxford	8
25	“You cannot easily substitute anymore.”	**Monika Zurek** University of Oxford	8
26	…she pushed back against “panic and fear”…	**Katie White** UK climate minister	9
27	…Britons they should “store a bit of food that can keep you going for a while”…	**Angela Eagle** UK environment minister	9
28	“Look, am I going out and buying loads of extra beans? I’ve always got a few cans of beans, but that’s mainly so I’m ready for when I’ve not had a chance to go to the shop,”	**Katie White** UK climate minister	9
29	“So I’m not going out and doing that.”	**Katie White** UK climate minister	9
30	“We will have a wetter start to this winter… On the back of a very dry summer, that is difficult,”	**Katie White** UK climate minister	9
31	“The food system is vulnerable.”	**Katie White** UK climate minister	9
32	“I don’t think we need to be in a position of grain stores, but I do think we do need to be looking at where the vulnerabilities are in the food system and how we support local production in the most sustainable way,”	**Katie White** UK climate minister	9
33	“That’s going to be working with farmers and also on local supply chains.”	**Katie White** UK climate minister	9
34	But “grain storage is definitely part of the answer” as well…	**Monika Zurek** University of Oxford	9

El Niño special report (pages 4–11)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Who said it	Page
35	…this combination could lead to “social unrest and conflict in vulnerable countries, much as the global wheat crisis became a trigger of the Arab Spring”.	**Safe Climate Australia** think tank report	9
36	“If you have got increases in food and fuel prices, then the whole backlash is going to be against the local government,”	**Akshay Deoras** University of Reading	9
37	“That’s what all the farmers are talking about after that hot summer. Everyone should have their own borehole,”	**Rosa Farber** Laines Organic Farm, UK	9
38	“The summer really wiped us out.”	**Rosa Farber** Laines Organic Farm, UK	9
39	…would be a “major, major undertaking”…	**Katharine Ricke** University of California, San Diego	10
40	“The ecosystem effects of installing ocean pipes at that scale are really not well understood at all,”	**Katharine Ricke** University of California, San Diego	10
41	“It’s not something we could implement for this El Niño or maybe even the next one,”	**Jessica Wan** University of Chicago	10
42	“We’re combining heavy robotics and geotechnical innovation to literally reshape the world,”	**Laurence Allen** CEO, Terranova (2025 statement)	11
43	“I would question whether the soil structure would be stable enough over 20 or 30 years to actually support houses,”	**Nigel Wright** University of Birmingham	11
44	“That’s probably enough for us to stop the bleach,”	**Greg Qiao** University of Melbourne	11
45	“So, at this point, it is difficult to know precisely how the current El Niño will wind down,”	**Michael McPhaden** US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration	11

News: AI maths, fossils, health, archaeology, space, tattoos, ageing (pages 12–16)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Who said it	Page
46	“I worked on this problem for 25 years. I produced two books on it. I, personally, gave up,”	**Francis Johnson** University College London	12
47	“I’m surprised that [AI] has done it quite so quickly, but I’m not surprised that it’s done it.”	**Francis Johnson** University College London	12
48	…being “astonished with the sophistication and clarity of the analysis that they gave”.	**Francis Johnson** University College London	12
49	“Let’s face it, the genie is out of the bottle now. We’re going to have to live with it. Human beings are supposed to be adaptable, so we’re going to have to adapt. I think for the moment, we just stand back and be astonished,”	**Francis Johnson** University College London	12
50	…how discoveries are being made and “dumped” on the mathematical community may harm the field.	**Terence Tao** University of California, Los Angeles	13
51	…saying only that it was an “internal frontier model”.	**OpenAI**	13

News: AI maths, fossils, health, archaeology, space, tattoos, ageing (pages 12–16)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Who said it	Page
52	“we’re continuing to explore other community-hosted alternatives for this release which meet the committee’s guidelines. For future releases, we are committed to further improving the quality of the papers via the citations, mathematical exposition, and presentation of the results for better understanding. We want to give the mathematical community time and space to assess this work.”	**Lindsay McCallum Rémy** OpenAI (in an email)	13
53	“The back half of Megacauda is more similar to the platypus, of all mammals. But the skull and teeth are analogous to river otters,”	**Zhe-Xi Luo** University of Chicago	13
54	“The mammalian ways of swallowing and suckling are unique,”	**Zhe-Xi Luo** University of Chicago	13
55	Mammals’ throats can form “a suction vacuum for milk and squeeze the chewed food balls and liquid down their throats”…	**Zhe-Xi Luo** University of Chicago	13
56	“We used to know very little about the evolutionary pattern of pharyngeal and hyoid structure. Now we know their evolutionary origins went back to before the rise of the modern mammals,”	**Zhe-Xi Luo** University of Chicago	13
57	“It tells us that some key mammalian traits like sucking, which is required for behaviours like drinking milk from mothers, predate the origin of mammals today.”	**Oliver Griffith** Macquarie University, Sydney	13
58	He says it is “cool to see that this sister lineage to today’s mammals had evolved an aquatic lifestyle, which is something we have seen multiple times across the mammalian family tree”.	**Oliver Griffith** Macquarie University, Sydney	13
59	“The most important message is that atherosclerosis is already present in a meaningful fraction of people in their 20s and 30s,”	**Olli Raitakari** University of Turku, Finland	14
60	“Atherosclerosis is a lifelong process, not a disease of old age.”	**Olli Raitakari** University of Turku, Finland	14
61	“Neanderthal technology was not only made of stone; it was also made of wood,”	**Josep Vallverdú** Catalan Institute of Human Paleoecology and Social Evolution	15
62	“The archaeological record gives us a very biased picture of prehistoric technology. We see the stone because it survives, while a huge part of their material culture has simply disappeared.”	**Josep Vallverdú** Catalan Institute of Human Paleoecology and Social Evolution	15
63	…surprised at how “complex Neanderthal woodworking could be, and how well they understood the properties of wood”…	**María Gema Chacón** Catalan Institute of Human Paleoecology and Social Evolution	15
64	“Producing long, straight shafts and shaping them deliberately into pointed weapons required planning, skill and careful selection of the raw material,”	**María Gema Chacón** Catalan Institute of Human Paleoecology and Social Evolution	15
65	“We have evidence of woodworking across many archaeological levels and over thousands of years, and the objects are associated with very different activities: hunting, domestic tasks, containers and the organisation of living spaces,”	**Josep Vallverdú** Catalan Institute of Human Paleoecology and Social Evolution	15
66	“This is of course evidence from only one site, in one area, and one time span,” … “so it’s just the tip of the iceberg in terms of a whole and mostly hidden technology that ran in parallel with the much better-known stone tools of the Palaeolithic.”	**Chris Stringer** Natural History Museum, London	15

News: AI maths, fossils, health, archaeology, space, tattoos, ageing (pages 12–16)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Who said it	Page
67	“On the scale of billions of years, asteroids of this size should hit each other and reaccumulate,”	**Dmitrii Vavilov** University of Washington, Seattle	15
68	“You can simply turn the tattoo off whenever you don’t want to see it and it disappears from view,”	**Carson Bruns** University of Colorado Boulder	16
69	With PhotoTat, “ultraviolet light writes the colour in, bright visible light erases it, and the cycle can be repeated”…	**Carson Bruns** University of Colorado Boulder	16
70	“The tattoo is permanent, but its appearance is not.”	**Carson Bruns** University of Colorado Boulder	16
71	“The colour-changing [dye] toxicity is unknown, but the toxicity of most tattoo pigments is equally unknown.”	**Carson Bruns** University of Colorado Boulder	16
72	“This study adds to the body of evidence that the mechanisms of ageing may be conserved across species,”	**Stephen Clark** Kallel Foundation, Nashville	16
73	“We found 287 genes that had changes in them that were unique to him,”	**Stephen Clark** Kallel Foundation, Nashville	16
74	“This, in turn, has helped him manage the effects of ageing by giving the DNA repair systems more energy from the mitochondria to fight off the effects of ageing.”	**Stephen Clark** Kallel Foundation, Nashville	16

Views, culture & features (pages 19–35)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Who said it	Page
75	“The world fears mathematicians, Hannah. Let’s keep it that way.”	**A professor of algebraic number theory** quoted by Hannah Fry	19
76	…collaborators that, as Mollick puts it, are “genuinely powerful and genuinely unreliable”.	**Ethan Mollick** author of Co-Existence; Wharton business school	26
77	…namely that “AI is not a replacement for your own thinking, and the value it provides depends entirely on how you choose to use it”.	**Ethan Mollick** author of Co-Existence; Wharton business school	26
78	As Mollick says, “the people who benefit the most are the ones who actually bother to try”.	**Ethan Mollick** author of Co-Existence; Wharton business school	27
79	…locals describe their yowling vocalisations on ridges as “singing”.	**Locals in the Indian Himalayas** describing snow leopards	27
80	“Claude’s ears will be burning by the end of the week,”	**A fellow passenger** on the Galapagos trip	32
81	“It’s the defining topic of our era that we will have to grapple with practically and socially,”	**Ned Block** philosopher, New York University	32
82	“We can take [an event] that was extraordinarily brief, like a shooting star, and think about it for as long as needed,”	**Stanislas Dehaene** cognitive neuroscientist, Collège de France	33
83	“Consciousness is a bottleneck,”	**Stanislas Dehaene** cognitive neuroscientist, Collège de France	33

Views, culture & features (pages 19–35)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Who said it	Page
84	“The global workspace that we originally postulated for human consciousness seems to also exist and have similar properties in these animals,”	**Stanislas Dehaene** cognitive neuroscientist, Collège de France	34
85	“That connects directly to a line of research in my lab where we looked at the consciousness of errors,”	**Stanislas Dehaene** cognitive neuroscientist, Collège de France	34
86	“There is a sort of ignition when you realise that you’ve made a mistake.”	**Stanislas Dehaene** cognitive neuroscientist, Collège de France	34
87	“The J-space emerges exactly for the reason that we think that consciousness emerged in evolution,”	**Stanislas Dehaene** cognitive neuroscientist, Collège de France	34
88	“It’s an extremely useful architecture for selecting relevant information and holding it long enough that you can use it flexibly in your reasoning and reporting.”	**Stanislas Dehaene** cognitive neuroscientist, Collège de France	34
89	“What an amazing place to be conscious,”	**Susan Schneider** philosopher, Florida Atlantic University	34
90	“Would you get a different kind of consciousness, or something other than consciousness?”	**Peter Godfrey-Smith** philosopher, University of Sydney	35
91	“When it comes to machines, can’t we be satisfied with the computational level?”	**Stanislas Dehaene** cognitive neuroscientist, Collège de France	35
92	“If you want to build a plane, you’d better not use feathers.”	**Stanislas Dehaene** cognitive neuroscientist, Collège de France	35
93	“I think that, in itself, is a reason to doubt that Claude has any experiences,”	**Peter Godfrey-Smith** philosopher, University of Sydney	35
94	“We’re still waiting for the major breakthrough,”	**Tim Bayne** philosopher, Monash University	35
95	“You can spend a week on a boat and visit a lot of cool islands,”	**Tim Bayne** philosopher, Monash University	35
96	“At the end of the week, you’re back where you were dropped off – but you’re not the same person.”	**Tim Bayne** philosopher, Monash University	35
97	As a field, he says, “I think that’s where we’re at”.	**Tim Bayne** philosopher, Monash University	35

Cancer in the crosshairs (pages 37–39)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Who said it	Page
98	“I had multiple spots all in my lungs, my neck, my spine, my liver, my brain – just everywhere,”	**Stephen Huff** lung cancer survivor	37
99	“I put on a brave front, but deep down I was terrified. I didn’t know if I’d be here in six months.”	**Stephen Huff** lung cancer survivor	37
100	…Huff “hit the lottery”…	**Huff’s oncologist**	37
101	“My first scan showed that basically every tumour site had either shrunk or gone away completely,”	**Stephen Huff** lung cancer survivor	37

Cancer in the crosshairs (pages 37–39)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Who said it	Page
102	“Being able to identify exactly what makes a cancer tick is having an incredible impact,”	**David Thomas** precision oncology pioneer, University of New South Wales	37
103	“Cancer is fundamentally a genetic disease,”	**David Thomas** precision oncology pioneer, University of New South Wales	37
104	“So, by pinpointing the precise genes responsible for cancer, and rationally designing drugs to target those individual genes, we are making rapid strides.”	**David Thomas** precision oncology pioneer, University of New South Wales	37
105	“It was so successful we had patients flying over from Western Australia so they could take part,”	**David Thomas** precision oncology pioneer, University of New South Wales	38
106	“Now, about 48.5 per cent are getting a strong recommendation, meaning we know with reasonable confidence that they will live longer if they receive the recommended treatment,”	**David Thomas** precision oncology pioneer, University of New South Wales	38
107	“We’ve found that over 30 per cent of patients with pancreatic cancer who receive a good treatment recommendation are alive past five years, compared to 4 per cent who don’t get a match,”	**David Thomas** precision oncology pioneer, University of New South Wales	38
108	“This supports optimal treatment for standard care, but there’s untapped potential for identifying people who could be recruited into clinical trials for new treatments,”	**Matthew Krebs** oncologist, University of Manchester	38
109	“There’s quite a bit of competition in terms of different academic centres wanting to have programmes like this for their catchment areas,”	**Jens Rueter** Maine Cancer Genomics Initiative, Jackson Laboratory	38
110	“Life is really good; I’m just trying to cherish it for as long as I can,”	**Stephen Huff** lung cancer survivor	39
111	“He went in and had an MRI, and they called us and said, ‘It’s gone’,”	**Kristen** mother of Jack Kennelly	39
112	“Words can’t really express how incredible that feeling was.”	**Kristen** mother of Jack Kennelly	39
113	Jack is now 7, and “just little things like school assemblies are different for us because he’s up there doing his thing, he is full of joy, and we’re so thankful every day that he is still with us”…	**Kristen** mother of Jack Kennelly	39
114	“The next thing will be his thyroid,”	**Kristen** mother of Jack Kennelly	39
115	…he now believes “more than ever” that children dying from cancer will eventually become a thing of the past.	**Louis Chesler** director, Children’s Cancer Institute, Sydney	39
116	“It’s not a matter of if, but when,”	**Louis Chesler** director, Children’s Cancer Institute, Sydney	39
117	“It’s the most empowering time I can ever think of to be a researcher or clinician in medicine.”	**Louis Chesler** director, Children’s Cancer Institute, Sydney	39
118	“Fortunately, I have a cancer that is responding to some of these brilliant treatments,”	**David Thomas** precision oncology pioneer, University of New South Wales	39
119	“At this point, I don’t think I’m likely to be cured, but I am still able to make a meaningful contribution, both professionally and personally,”	**David Thomas** precision oncology pioneer, University of New South Wales	39

Cancer in the crosshairs (pages 37–39)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Who said it	Page
120	“I’m a poster child of what modern medicine can achieve.”	**David Thomas** precision oncology pioneer, University of New South Wales	39

Feedback (page 48)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Who said it	Page
121	…which describe themselves as “the industry leaders in filming products, items, and bespoke activations in space”.	**Sent Into Space** balloon-launch company	48
122	She notes that 35 km is “well below the Kármán line”…	**Kelsey Hayes** New Scientist chief subeditor	48
123	“Imagine getting beaned by a Le Creuset Dutch oven dropped from 110,000 feet.”	**Kelsey Hayes** New Scientist chief subeditor	48
124	“Participants rated their attractiveness on a 0–100 scale,”	**Study in Evolutionary Psychology**	48
125	…a key line in the abstract – “higher self-rated attractiveness was associated with being male” – …	**Study in Evolutionary Psychology** abstract	48
126	…and simply said “LOL”.	**Alexandra Thompson** New Scientist assistant news editor	48
127	In contrast, “cognitive ability showed a small negative association with SAPA”.	**Study in Evolutionary Psychology**	48
128	“There is a vast literature on the beauty premium, which suggests that, in males, and possibly more in females, physical attractiveness is a considerable asset in all competitive situations such as mate selection.”	**Study authors** Evolutionary Psychology	48

Part 2 – Pull quotes (the large highlighted quotes on the pages)

#	Quote (exactly as printed)	Whose words	Page
1	“Being able to identify exactly what makes a cancer tick is having an incredible impact”	**David Thomas** contents page and cancer feature	1, 39
2	“With preparation, rich societies should be able to withstand almost any extreme weather”	**The leader (editorial)**	3
3	“It gives us a glimpse of what is coming if we continue to warm the planet with carbon”	**Michael Mann** University of Pennsylvania	4
4	“This super El Niño event will drive multiple climate-regime shifts like we’ve seen after past ones”	**Jeff Masters** hurricane specialist	5
5	“The longer you have to prepare, the more options you have. And the better off you may be in the end”	**Michael McPhaden** US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration	7
6	“While countries like India have built grain stores to buffer these shocks, the UK and the US haven’t”	**Article text** Alec Luhn	8
7	“If you have increases in food prices, then the whole backlash is going to be against the government”	**Akshay Deoras** University of Reading	9
8	“Artificial upwelling could be used to potentially prevent an El Niño from forming”	**Article text** Madeleine Cuff	10

Part 2 – Pull quotes (the large highlighted quotes on the pages)

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9	“Gene editing or selective breeding could add a heat-tolerant trait to commercial rice crops”	**Article text** Madeleine Cuff	11
10	“Let’s face it, the genie is out of the bottle now. We’re going to have to live with it”	**Francis Johnson** University College London	12
11	“With such a huge body of research all dropping at once, it could take years for mathematicians to check”	**Article text** Leah Crane and Matthew Sparkes	13
12	“Atherosclerosis is already present in a meaningful fraction of people in their 20s and 30s”	**Olli Raitakari** University of Turku, Finland	14
13	Atherosclerosis, the build-up of fatty plaque in arteries, is “not a disease of old age”	**Olli Raitakari** University of Turku, Finland	14
14	“The technological behaviours preserved are comparable to those seen for Homo sapiens”	**María Gema Chacón** Catalan Institute of Human Paleoecology and Social Evolution	15
15	“OpenAI set its sights on mathematics because the prestige and glory was just another thing that could be mined”	**Hannah Fry** columnist	19
16	“The amount of sugar they had as babies 70 years ago seems to still be influencing their health today”	**Alice Klein** columnist	20
17	“The book’s real value lies in the way it makes us reimagine what we might do as we learn to co-exist with AI”	**Daniel Cossins** reviewer	26
18	“I have already forced two people to buy the book, which is always a sign that I think something is special”	**Emily H. Wilson** sci-fi columnist	28
19	“Could consciousness exist without a hum of activity and constant interaction with an environment?”	**David Robson** feature writer	34
20	“Roman is going to bring us deep insights into the nature of dark energy, but also dark matter”	**Kristen McQuinn** head of the Roman Space Telescope mission office	40
21	“The first image taken by the telescope is so full of promise – everybody is so excited”	**Kristen McQuinn** head of the Roman Space Telescope mission office	43
22	“Emotional tears may not originally have evolved as a signal, but simply accompanied intense emotional arousal”	**Mike Follows** reader, Sutton Coldfield	46
23	“Perhaps many dogs don’t look at aeroplanes because we don’t, and that if we do, it results in nothing they want”	**Keith Wright** reader, Manchester	47